▶ WEST BENGAL

What's Cooking?



When is too *maachh* (fish) too much? Never enough in poll season, one can safely presume. So, after taking on Prime Minister Narendra Modi for his remarks on the fish- and mutton-eating habits of Opposition leaders, West Bengal chief minister and Trinamool Congress supremo **Mamata Banerjee** proposed to cook for him. Speaking at a poll rally in Barrackpore on May 13, she wondered if the prime minister would trust her cooking, since she has been doing so since childhood and invited many a compliment for it. If you're a Bengali, you could not possibly have missed the occasional sighting of Mamata wielding the ladle in her kitchen during Kali Puja or frying an *alur chop* or two or stopping to make a cuppa at a roadside stall while on an election or administrative tour. Didi also professed her love for both the Gujarati savoury *dhokla* as well as the Bengali staple *maachher jhol*. Before you wondered where all this inviting talk was leading up to, Mamata delivered a sour punch, saying Modi's comments on the dietary habits of others "shows that the BJP leadership has little idea of and concern for the diversity and inclusivity of India and its people". Enough to choke you on all that goodness, one supposes. ■



FOLK LURE

Katni singers in Bihar, Aalha-Udal folk songs in Bundelkhand, Mandyali-Chambyali ones in Himachal... political parties are relying on some local spice to add *tadka* to their political campaign. The harvest season for Rabi is on, enough cause already for revelry and folk singing; election season has thrown up more reason for celebration. And who better than folk singers with their strong social media following to add a touch of virality and outreach? So, from providing background scores for a *neta's* digital campaign to the plain old need to set the mood, '*sama baandhana*' as it's called, folk singers suddenly are a much sought-after segment. And not for their vote but for what they can do to get others, especially the grassroots electorate, to vote. So whether

Illustrations by **SIDDHANT JUMDE**

▶ JHARKHAND

SITA AUR GEETA (2024)

With former chief minister Hemant Soren denied bail, it has fallen upon Kalpana Soren to fight her husband's battles. Part of that includes challenging Sita *aur* Geeta, one her sister-in-law, the other the wife of convicted politician Madhu Koda, both recent acquisitions of the BJP. **Sita Soren**, previously a Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) legislator, quit the family and JMM in March, saying she was being neglected and is now contesting on a BJP ticket from Dumka, which goes to the polls on June 1. The constituency is of symbolic value for the family, being a traditional party stronghold and represented by its patriarch, Shibu Soren. **Geeta Koda**, meanwhile, will continue to represent family bastion Singhbhum, though as a BJP candidate this time instead of the Congress.